

127 James, son of Zebedee

A "son of thunder" who asked for glory and was given a cup of suffering.

James was a Galilean fisherman, the son of Zebedee and brother of John. With Peter and John he formed Jesus' inner circle, seeing a dead girl raised and Jesus transfigured. Jesus nicknamed the brothers "the sons of thunder." They once wanted to call down fire on a Samaritan village, and they asked for the best seats in Christ's kingdom. Jesus told them they would drink his cup, and for James that came true first. He is the only one of the Twelve whose martyrdom the New Testament records, killed by Herod Agrippa I in AD 44.

At a glance

Name	Greek <i>Iakobos</i> , from the Hebrew Jacob
Family	Son of Zebedee; brother of John the apostle (Mark 1:19)
Mother	"The mother of Zebedee's children"; probably Salome
Work	Fisherman in a family business, partner of Simon (Luke 5:10)
Nickname	Boanerges, "the sons of thunder" (Mark 3:17)
Death	Killed with the sword by Herod, AD 44 (Acts 12:1-2)
Not the same as	James, son of Alphaeus, or James, brother of Jesus

"Now about that time Herod the king stretched forth his hands to vex certain of the church. And he killed James the brother of John with the sword."

Acts 12:1-2, KJV

The life of James, son of Zebedee

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study.
The date of James's death is firm, because Herod Agrippa I died in AD 44.

- c. AD 28

Sea of Galilee

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Called from the boat

Jesus finds James and John mending nets with their father Zebedee. They leave their father in the ship with the hired servants and follow Jesus. *Mark 1:19–20*
- c. AD 28

On a mountain

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Chosen and named

Jesus appoints the Twelve and gives James and his brother the name Boanerges, "the sons of thunder."
Mark 3:13–17
- c. AD 29

On a high mountain

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Sees the glory

James, Peter and John watch Jesus transfigured, his clothes shining, as Moses and Elijah talk with him. *Mark 9:2–8*
- c. AD 30

Road to Jerusalem

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Asks for a throne

James and John ask to sit at Jesus' right and left hand in his glory. Jesus asks if they can drink his cup, and they say they can. *Mark 10:35–40*
- AD 44

Jerusalem

●

Killed by Herod

King Herod Agrippa I turns against the church and has James put to death with the sword, the first of the Twelve to die for Christ. *Acts 12:1–2*

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew says the mother of James and John made the request for seats of glory, while Mark has the brothers ask. Both agree that Jesus answered the brothers directly.

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- 1 **Left his father and his nets.** He walked away from the family business to follow Jesus. *Mark 1:19-20; Matthew 4:21-22*
 - 2 **Saw a dead girl raised.** Jesus let only Peter, James and John go in with Jairus's family. *Mark 5:37-43*
 - 3 **Saw the Transfiguration.** He was one of three witnesses on the mountain. *Mark 9:2-8*
 - 4 **Wanted fire from heaven.** When a Samaritan village refused Jesus, James and John asked if they should call down fire "even as Elias did." Jesus rebuked them. *Luke 9:51-56*
 - 5 **Asked for glory.** He and John asked for the places of honor, and Jesus answered, "Ye know not what ye ask." *Mark 10:35-45; Matthew 20:20-28*
 - 6 **Asked about the end.** With Peter, John and Andrew he asked Jesus privately about the temple's fall. *Mark 13:3-4*
 - 7 **Was called to watch in Gethsemane.** Jesus took the three aside as he began to be sore amazed and very heavy, but they fell asleep. *Mark 14:32-41*
 - 8 **Drank the cup.** He became the first apostle to die as a martyr. *Acts 12:1-2*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Tradition, not Scripture: his accuser confessed Christ and died with him (Eusebius); a medieval story links him to Spain and Santiago de Compostela.

Old Testament

Echo: 2 Kings 1:9–12	Elijah's fire, which the brothers wanted to copy
Echo: Isaiah 51:17	"The cup" of God's fury, which Jesus drinks himself

New Testament

Matthew 10:2; Mark 3:17; Acts 1:13	Among the first names of the Twelve
Mark 5:37; 9:2; 14:33	One of the three closest to Jesus
Mark 10:35–45	"To give his life a ransom for many"
John 21:2	"The sons of Zebedee" meet the risen Jesus
Acts 12:1–2	His death, told in one verse

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus ask James and John, and how did they answer (Mark 10:38–39)?
2. *Understand:* What does Jesus' rebuke about fire show about his kingdom?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to seek recognition instead of service?
4. *Apply:* James's death is told in one verse. What unseen faithfulness is God asking of you?